

Breaking New Ground: Establishing Graphics Worldwide

SIGGRAPH 2022 Retrospective Panel

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1 OVERVIEW

This Retrospective panel welcomes four individuals who have been active in establishing and growing computer graphics in their home regions of the world. The panelists include the Program Chair of the first SIGGRAPH conference; a founding member of the Eurographics Portuguese Chapter; the force behind many SIGGRAPH "firsts" such as Conference T-shirts; and a man who has untiringly promoted computer graphics in Brazil and Latin America. You'll learn how their efforts were both unique to their time and place and similar.

Because the panel was included in the virtual program of SIGGRAPH 2022, it was restricted to one hour. Consequently, individual responses from the panelists were limited to two minutes.

2 THE PANEL TOPICS

This Retrospective is about how computer graphics expanded both throughout the United States and into different parts of the world. An important part of the stories of the expansion is the role of professional societies and organizations—international, national, regional, and local.

Our panelists have worked in computer graphics in North and South America and in Europe. They include Jon Meads, the Program Chair of the first SIGGRAPH conference (1974, Boulder, CO, USA); Maxine Brown, the person behind many of SIGGRAPH's

"firsts" including the first conference T-shirt (San Jose, CA, 1977); Joaquim Jorge, a founding member of the Eurographics Portuguese Chapter (1988); and Marcelo Zuffo from Brazil. Marcelo is a long-time SIGGRAPH contributor who was International Chair for the SIGGRAPH 2000 Conference.

Each panelist first described how they became involved in computer graphics and what unique perspective they brought to this panel. Then, they addressed the topics that follow.

- In the late 1960s and the early 1970s, there was little computer graphics anywhere outside a few Universities. What happened to make computer graphics an accepted and then respected academic discipline?
- SIGGRAPH was founded in 1969 as an ACM Special Interest Committee. What role does a professional society play? What were the challenges and benefits of starting national, regional, or local professional societies or chapters?
- What was the hardest thing and the most rewarding thing about your work establishing Computer Graphics in your part of the world?
- Tell us about a person, besides yourself, whose leadership and vision helped establish graphics in your homeland.
- What role has SIGGRAPH played in your life and career?

Today's graphics technologies and applications are a new and fluid landscape. We hope the audience will take the lessons passed along by our panelists of worldwide graphics pioneers and apply them in ways that will continue to break new ground.

3 THE MEMBERS OF THE PANEL

Mary Whitton (moderator) has worked in interactive 3D graphics research since the mid-1970s. She studied at NC State University and was co-founder of Ikonas Graphics Systems (1978) and Trancept Systems (1986). These companies developed high-end user-programmable graphics processors that were predecessors of today's GPUs. She joined UNC in 1994 and from then until 2016 she co-lead the Effective Virtual Environments research group with Fred Brooks. She received the 2021 IEEE Virtual Reality VGTC Career Award. Whitton was the Chair of the ACM SIGGRAPH Executive Committee from 1993 to 1995 and is currently Chair of the ACM SIGGRAPH History Committee.

Jon Meads is a graphics pioneer. Jon managed and developed graphic software systems since the 1970s, focusing on the human side of interaction. He spent several years as a software engineer and manager developing interactive systems and was a Member of

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the Scientific Staff for Bell-Northern Research. He founded Usability Architects, Inc., a firm specializing in user-centered design. Jon is a former chair of SIGGRAPH, a co-chair of the first SIGGRAPH conference, served as a member of the SIGCHI Advisory Board, Co-Chaired CHI '90, has been a speaker and panelist at a number of conferences, and has served as an ACM National Lecturer.

Maxine D. Brown is a Visiting Senior Research Scientist at the Electronic Visualization Laboratory (EVL) at the University of Illinois Chicago (UIC), and previously served as EVL Director (2014-2020) and Associate Director (1986-2014). Her research interests include computer graphics, scientific visualization, collaboration, human-computer interfaces, high-performance computing, and international network infrastructure. Brown was active in the ACM SIGGRAPH organization and conference, 1976-1998, and is the recipient of the 1998 ACM SIGGRAPH Outstanding Service Award. She is also a featured contributor in *New Media Futures: The Rise of Women in the Digital Arts*, published by the University of Illinois Press (2018).

Joaquim Jorge coordinates the Graphics research group at INESC-ID and holds the UNESCO Chair of AI&Extended Reality at

the University of Lisboa, Portugal. He joined Eurographics in 1986 and SIGGRAPH in 1989. He is Editor-in-Chief of the *Computers and Graphics Journal*, Eurographics Fellow, ACM Distinguished Speaker and Member, and IEEE Distinguished Visitor and Contributor. He organized 50+ conferences, including Eurographics 2016 (IPC CO-Chair), IEEE VR 2020-2021-2022 as co-(papers) chair and ACM IUI 2012 (IPC co-chair). He served on 210+ program committees and (co)authored over 360 peer-reviewed publications and five books. His research interests include graphics, virtual reality, and advanced HCI techniques.

Marcelo Knörich Zuffo is the Director of InovaUSP, University of São Paulo Innovation Center, Director of the Interdisciplinary Center on Interactive Technologies, and a full professor at the USP Polytechnic School. He designed and implemented the first Digital Cave in Latin America. He had a key activity in the definition of the Brazilian Digital TV System, which is widely adopted in Latin America. He has continually participated in the SIGGRAPH community since 1991 and, in 2000, he was the International SIGGRAPH chair. During the Covid-19 pandemic, he was one of the mentors of Inspire, a project to design and manufacture mechanical respirators.